



AI-ASSISTED RESEARCH METHODOLOGY

AI-Assisted Research Programming

From Vibe Coding to Spec-Driven Development

A Practical Guide for Researchers

PRESENTER

[Jiale Guo]

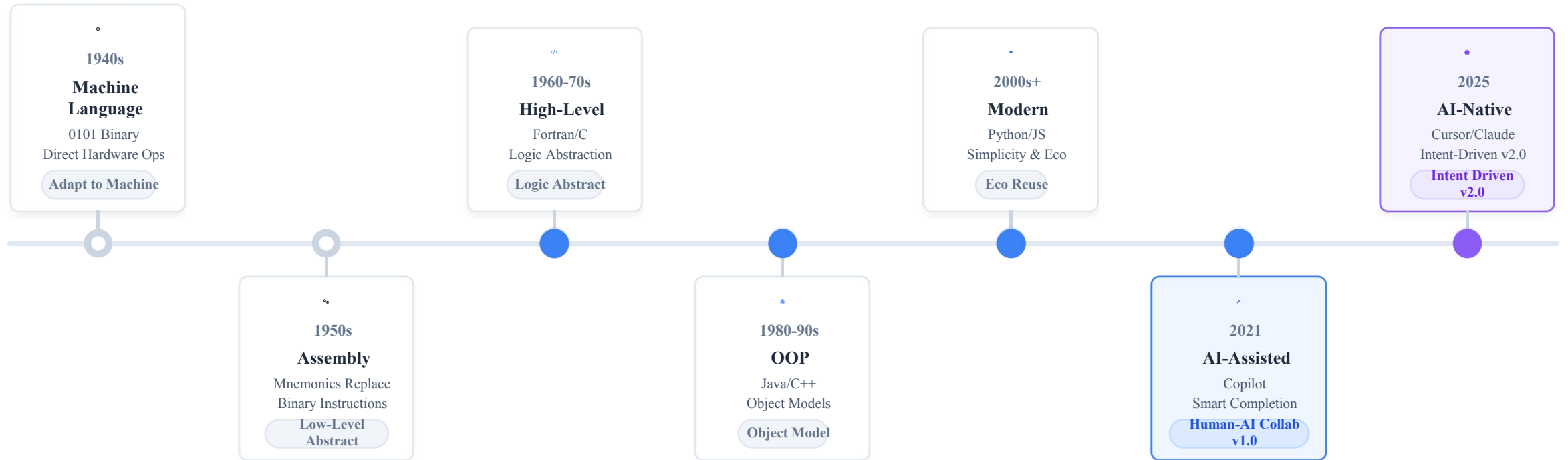
DATE

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2024_Fall_MSc_Geoinformatics Engineering
Politecnico di Milano

1.0 Programming Evolution

From Humans Adapting to Machines to Machines Serving People



Evolutionary Law

Programming abstraction layers rise continuously; HCI approaches natural language.

NEXT STEP

Prompt Engineering Is The New Coding

Core Shift

Traditional = Human → Machine Language

AI Programming = Human → AI → Collaborative Code

From "Syntax Recall"
To "Prompt Engineering"

Key Dimension Comparison

Dimension	Traditional Programming	AI Programming	Nature of Change
Core Skills	Syntax recall, API lookup	Requirement description, Logic validation	Memory → Expression
Learning Curve	Steep Months-Years	Gentle Days-Weeks	Lower Barrier
Dev Speed	Slow (Manual write + Manual debug)	Fast (Instant generation + Iterate)	Efficiency Leap
Scope	All scenarios (incl. low-level drivers)	80% Routine research tasks	Pareto Principle

AI Strengths

- Standard algorithms (Sorting, Stats, GIS ops)
- Code translation (Python ↔ R)
- Error diagnosis & Fix suggestions (Explain & Fix)
- Automated documentation & comments

AI Limitations

- Complex domain logic (Needs deep knowledge)
- Novel algorithm design (Non-standard/New)
- System-level architecture decisions
- Extreme performance optimization (Hardware level)

Vibe Coding

Natural language conversation-driven, exploratory, intuition-based programming method characterized by rapid trial-and-error iteration.

Three Core Features



Low Barrier

No complex syntax required, natural language is code



High Speed

Idea to code in minutes, rapid validation



Strong Exploration

Discover unknown possibilities via dialogue

👍 Recommended

- ✓ Code < 200 lines
- ✓ One-off scripts
- ✓ Rapid prototypes
- ✓ Learning new stacks

🚫 Avoid

- × Code > 500 lines
- × Long-term maintenance
- × Team projects
- × Core algorithms

⚠️ Three Fatal Flaws

📁 Scale Disaster

500+ lines become a "patch pile", lacking architecture, maintenance cost rises exponentially.

💬 Understanding Drift

Term ambiguity (e.g., "building density" definitions), AI lacks context and won't clarify proactively.

📄 Doc Drift

Code changes without doc updates lead to inconsistency, rendering documentation useless.

Core Shift: From Dialogue-Driven to Spec-Driven (Contract)



Vibe Coding = Verbal House Building

"Ad-hoc changes, building as you speak"

✖ Result: Crooked house, missed details

Spec-Driven = Blueprints First

"Blueprints define all details and standards"

✔ Result: Quality assured, reproducible

“

"Vibe Coding is Fast Food—tasty but unhealthy. Spec-Driven is Healthy Fast Food—fast AND reliable."



AI-Native IDEs

Complete development environment, deeply integrated AI

[Cursor](#) [Windsurf](#) [Antigravity](#) [Trae](#) [Kiro](#) [Augment](#)

- ✓ For medium-large projects
- ✓ Deep context understanding
- ✓ Agent mode: Autonomous development



CLI Tools

Geek's choice, scripts & automation

[Claude Code](#) [Codex CLI](#) [Gemini CLI](#) [Droid](#)

- ✓ For complex reasoning & deep logic
- ✓ Automation & task decomposition
- ✓ Huge context window (200K - 1M)



Cloud Platforms

Online development, zero configuration

[Replit](#) [bolt.new](#) [Lovable](#) [Orchids](#)

- ✓ Zero setup, browser-ready
- ✓ Real-time full-stack preview
- ✓ Ideal for teaching & prototypes



Auxiliary Tools

Specific task enhancement & visualization

[Augment Code](#) [Zread](#) [NotebookLM](#) [Mermaid Chart](#)

- ✓ Context engine enhancement
- ✓ Document interpretation
- ✓ Architecture visualization



Core Advice: Combinations beat single tools

Recommended Research Combo: AI-Native IDE (for building projects) + CLI Tools (for deep reasoning)



Updated 2025
Data

Cursor

BENCHMARK



\$20 Pro / \$40 Business

Claude 4.5 Sonnet / GPT-5.2

Agent Mode: Autonomous project-level dev

Composer: Multi-file editing & refactoring

@Symbols: Precise context referencing

.cursorrules: Project-specific norms

📖 Research Value: Complex Algorithms

Windsurf

VALUE KING



\$15/mo (~1000 credits)

Cascade Flow / Claude4.5 / GPT 5.2

Cascade Flow: Iterative coding system

Context: Strong multi-file awareness

Cost: 25% cheaper than Cursor

Agentic: First agent-IDE (2024 debut)

🧪 Research Value: Data Scripts & Prototyping

Antigravity

FREE GEM



Completely FREE

Claude Opus 4.5 + Gemini 3.0 Pro

Multi-Agent: Async task processing

Cross-Platform: Sync VSCode/Web/Terminal

Ecosystem: Seamless Google integration

Zero Cost: Best for students/academics

🎓 Research Value: Students & Exploration

T

Trae

FREE (China)

- Doubao / Claude 4.5
- ✓ ByteDance Localized Solution
 - ✓ 10 fast + 50 slow requests/mo
 - ✓ No proxy required, direct access
 - ✓ Real-time Web preview
 - ✓ Best for Chinese docs & teaching

LOCALIZATION

★★★★☆

K

Kiro

\$20 / \$40 / \$200

- Model Agnostic
- ✓ Spec-Driven Development (SDD)
 - ✓ Auto-maintained Memory Bank
 - ✓ Production-grade quality assurance
 - ✓ Enforced "Docs First" workflow
 - ✓ Ideal for large collaboration

SPEC-DRIVEN

★★★★★

A

Augment

\$100 / mo

- Context Engine + GPT-5.2
- ✓ Extreme Context Engine (RAG+)
 - ✓ 208,000 Credits monthly
 - ✓ Native MCP tool integration
 - ✓ SOC 2 Type II Enterprise Security
 - ✓ Best for huge legacy codebases

CONTEXT KING

★★★★★



Claude Code

PRO/MAX

Core Model

Claude 4.5 Sonnet / Opus

Pricing

\$20 Pro / \$200 Max

✓ Project Memory

✓ Multi-step Decomp.

✓ 200K Context

✓ Deep Code Analysis

Best For: Large project refactoring, precise paper algorithm implementation



Codex CLI

PLUS

Core Model

GPT-5.2

Pricing

\$20 Plus / \$200 Pro

✓ Native Multimodal

✓ Plugin Ecosystem

✓ Real-time Web Search

✓ Fast API Integration

Best For: Rapid prototyping, API integration, multimodal tasks



Gemini CLI

FREE

Core Model

Gemini 3.0 Pro

Pricing

Free (60 req/min)

✓ 1M Context Window

✓ Zero Cost Processing

✓ Gemini 3.0 Flash

✓ Search Integration

Best For: Zero budget projects, large text analysis, students



Droid

FACTORY

Vendor

Factory AI

Pricing

Subscription / API Key

✓ Deep CI/CD Integration

✓ Automated Pipelines

✓ Code Isolation

✓ Enterprise Compliance

Best For: Enterprise DevOps automation, batch refactoring

> CLI Core Value: Pipeline workflows & automation — "Refactor this" for huge codebases without manual intervention.

gemini "refactor this" < main.py > main_v2.py

2.4 Cloud Platforms: Replit / bolt.new / Lovable / Orchids

Zero-setup online environments for rapid prototyping & teaching

Replit

Free / Paid

- ✓ Browser-based IDE with zero environment setup requirement
- ✓ Real-time collaborative editing (Google Docs style)
- ✓ Instant Node.js runtime & one-click deployment

Best for: Teaching, Demos, Quick Prototyping, Sharing Scripts

bolt.new

Free / Paid

- ✓ Modern full-stack environment based on WebContainers
- ✓ Instant run & live preview with hot-reloading
- ✓ Seamless StackBlitz integration for web apps

Best for: Web App Development, Frontend Demos, Full-stack Projects

Lovable

~\$20/mo

- ✓ Automated full-stack app generation (Product-focused)
- ✓ High-quality UI design generation out-of-the-box
- ✓ Integrated database & backend logic setup

Best for: Rapid MVPs, Non-technical Founders, Tool Building

Orchids

Free Trial

- ✓ Leader in UI Bench benchmarks for interface generation
- ✓ Specialized in building complex interactive interfaces
- ✓ Ideal for creating visualized research tool interfaces

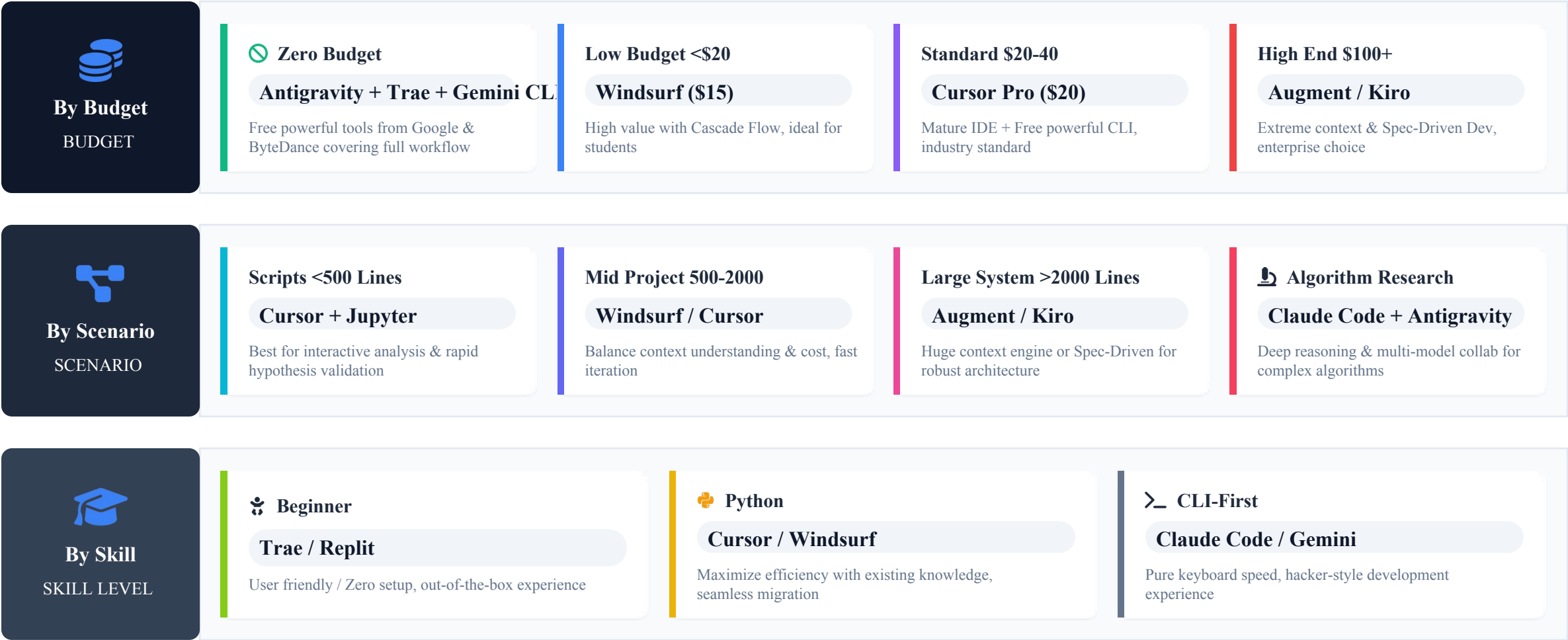
Best for: Research Dashboards, Experiment Control Panels, Complex UIs

 **Key Insight: Accessibility vs Performance**
Excellent for cross-device work and teaching. Note: Be mindful of upload/download bottlenecks when handling large local datasets (e.g., GB-sized imagery).

 Cloud-First

2.3 Tool Selection Decision Tree (2025)

Strategies for Tool Selection: Budget × Scenario × Skill





Philosophy (Dao)

Core Mindset & First Principles

- AI First: If AI can do it, humans shouldn't.
- Context is King: Garbage in, garbage out.
- Structure First: Plan before implementation.
- Occam's Razor: Do not add code unless necessary.



Methodology (Fa)

Systematic Implementation Principles

- Explicit Boundaries: One-sentence goal & non-goals.
- Orthogonality: Non-repetitive functional design.
- Docs as Context: Copy over writing; interface first.
- Interfaces First: Decompose modules by responsibility.



Meta-Methodology



Tactics (Shu)

Practical Execution Skills

- Constraints: State clearly what can/can't change.
- Debug Strategy: Expected vs Actual + minimal repro.
- Testing: AI generates tests, humans assert validity.
- Reset Session: Start fresh when code grows too large.



Tools (Qi)

Tool Selection & Combination

- ⚙️ IDEs: Cursor / Windsurf / Kiro
- CLI: Claude Code / Gemini CLI
- 💡 Models: Claude 3.5 / GPT-4o / Gemini 2.5
- See "Tool Panorama" for detailed comparison

🔍 Comparative Experiment: Why AI "Doesn't Understand"?

✖ Vague Description (Vibe Coding)

Result: Confusion

User: "Analyze this data for me"

AI Thinking: - Which dimension? (Stats? Regression?) - Which tool? (Pandas? Numpy?) - Output format? (Print? CSV? Plot?)

✔ Precise Description (Prompt Engineering)

Result: Success

User: "Read data.csv, calculate Mean/Median/Std of 'pop' column. Use Matplotlib to plot a bar chart. Save as output.png with 300dpi."

AI Understanding: Input: data.csv | Task: Stats + Plot Stack: Matplotlib | Output: 300dpi PNG

📦 5W1H Structural Framework

WHAT What is the specific task?Core function definition	WHY What is the business context?Context for intent
WHO Who is the target audience?Style & Depth level	WHEN Batch processing or real-time?Performance & Arch
WHERE Data source and output location?I/O Path definition	HOW Technical constraints & quality?Libs/Specs/Precision

🔗 Scientific Research Template

Task Description: [Verb] + [Object] + [Purpose]
Data Context: Source / Scale / Format
Processing Steps: Step 1... Step 2... (Logic Chain)
Output Requirements: Format / Precision / Metrics
Technical Constraints: Required Libs / Coding Style
Test Verification: Provide Mini Test Case

Specification-Driven Development (SDD) Overview

Core Principles, Basic Workflow & Three-Level Practice Path

Core Principle

Spec is the project's "Source of Truth", Code is merely the "Implementation Artifact".

Change Request → **Update Spec First** → AI Updates Code



Level 1

Spec-First Specification First

Ideal starting point for one-off tasks. Clearly define requirements first, then let AI generate code. Archive specs after generation.

- ✓ Applicable: <200 line scripts
- ✓ Higher quality than Vibe Coding



Level 2

Spec-Anchored Specification Anchored

Engineering standard. Specs and code are updated synchronously, serving as a long-term maintenance anchor. Requires Git management.

- ✓ Applicable: 500-2000 line projects
- ✓ Essential for team collaboration



Level 3

Spec-as-Source Specification as Source

Extreme automation. Edit only specs; code is fully auto-generated and strictly read-only, ensuring absolute consistency.

- ✓ Applicable: Structured/repetitive logic
- ✓ 100% consistency guarantee

CORE BENEFITS

 Fewer Detours

 Reproducibility

 Seamless Collab

 Maintainability

Standard Workflow

- 1 Define Requirements & Goals
- 2 Write Spec Document (Markdown)
- 3 AI Generates Code Based on Spec
- 4 Manual Review & Simple Testing
- 5 Task Complete, Archive Spec

APPLICABLE SCENARIOS

- ✓ Small Scripts (<200 lines)
- ✓ One-off Data Processing
- ✓ Quick Prototype Validation
- ✓ Learning New Tech Stacks

spec_poi_density.md

Example Spec

```
1 # Feature: POI Kernel Density Analysis
2
3 ## 1. Requirements Overview
4 Calculate kernel density of urban POIs, generate heatmap...
5
6 ## 2. Input Data
7 -pois.geojson : GeoDataFrame, Point Geometry, EPSG:4326
8 -boundary.shp : Study Area Boundary Polygon
9
10 ## 3. Output Deliverables
11 -density.tif : GeoTIFF Density Raster (Float32)
12 -heatmap.png : Visual Heatmap (300dpi, with legend)
13
14 ## 4. Algorithms & Parameters
15 - Method: Gaussian Kernel Density Estimation
16 - Bandwidth: Use Scott's rule adaptive calculation
17
18 ## 5. Code Requirements
19 - Function: calculate_kde(gdf, bandwidth=None) -> raster
20 - Must include Google-style docstrings
```

👍 Pros

Higher quality than pure chat; Documented and traceable

👎 Cons

Spec can become outdated; Not for complex iterations

⚓ Spec as Long-Term Anchor

For medium projects (500-2000 lines), code exceeds mental context limits. The Specification serves as the external memory and "source of truth" that must be kept in sync with code.

🔄 Synchronization Workflow



New Requirement / Bug Found



Update Spec Documentation First



AI Updates Code Based on New Spec

MEMORY BANK ARCHITECTURE

Project Structure

```
project_root/
├── .ai-context/ # AI Long-term Memory
│   ├── constitution.md # Non-negotiable rules
│   ├── architecture.md # System design
│   └── glossary.md # Domain terms
├── specs/ # Feature Specifications
│   └── feature-001/
│       ├── requirements.md
│       └── tests.md
└── src/ # Implementation Code
```


Extreme Automation

Code as Build Artifact

Treat the Spec as the source code. Generated code is a "build artifact" that is never manually edited. This guarantees 100% consistency between documentation and implementation.

data_models.yaml

EDITABLE SOURCE

```
User:
  fields:
    - id: UUID, primary_key
    - email: String, unique, required
  methods:
    -validate_email()      : bool
    -send_notify(msg)      : void
```

AI
COMPILER
→
AUTO GEN

models.py

DO NOT EDIT

```
# AUTO-GENERATED - DO NOT EDIT
from dataclasses import dataclass
from uuid import UUID

@dataclass
class User :
    id: UUID
    email: str

    def validate_email(self) -> bool:
        """Validate format logic..."""
        pass
```

BEST USE CASES

Data Models

API Schemas

Config Management

Multi-Platform Sync

AI Long-Term Memory

Use structured documentation as an external "Memory Bank" to maintain context across sessions.

 Add `.ai-context/` to `.gitignore` but include in AI context

Project Structure

```
project/
├── .ai-context/
│   ├── constitution.md    # Rules
│   ├── architecture.md   # Design
│   ├── glossary.md       # Terms
│   └── coding-standards.md
├── specs/
│   └── feature-001/
│       ├── requirements.md
│       └── tests.md
└── src/    # Code impl
```

constitution.md (Highest Priority)

Project Constitution: Urban POI System

Core Principles (Non-negotiable)

1. Data First: Use real data only, no fabrication.
2. Reproducibility: Every step must have a script.
3. Quality: Correctness > Speed.

Forbidden Items

- NO global variables
- NO 'from module import *'
- NO hardcoded paths

glossary.md (Eliminate Ambiguity)

Terminology Glossary

Building Density

Definition: Number of buildings per unit area.

Formula: $\text{density} = \text{count}(\text{buildings}) / \text{area}(\text{km}^2)$

Note: $\neq$ Building Coverage Ratio (Area Ratio)

Kernel Density Estimation (KDE)

Impl: `scipy.stats.gaussian_kde`

Param: `bandwidth` (default: Scott's rule)

Comparative Experiment: Two Paths for the Same Task

Vibe Coding vs Spec-First Performance Data

Task Goal

🎯 Calculate 15-min urban road network isochrones

📁 Input: Road SHP + Origin Point

📤 Output: GeoDataFrame (Polygon)

Method A: Vibe Coding

"Intuition-driven, ad-hoc changes"



- 1 Gen code v1 (AI used Euclidean dist)
- ✗ Debug: Switch to network dist (No NetworkX)
- ✗ Debug: Add NetworkX (Ignored speed limits)
- ✗ Debug: Add speed limits (Extremely slow)
- ... After 7 iterations, code structure is messy...

60 min

TOTAL TIME

7 x

DEBUG ROUNDS

60 pts

DOC COMPLETENESS

CODE QUALITY

⚠️ Barely usable, hard to maintain

Method B: Spec-First

"Contract-driven, spec before code"



- ✍️ Write Spec Document (5 min)
- 🤖 AI generates full code at once (2 min)
- ✓ Run unit tests: Passed (1 min)
- 📖 AI adds README docs (2 min)
- ✅ Final validation, no major logic errors

10 min

TOTAL TIME

0 x

DEBUG ROUNDS

90 pts

DOC COMPLETENESS

CODE QUALITY

★ High Quality, Reproducible

💡 Key Insight: Spending 5 mins on Spec saves 6x development time.

EFFICIENCY BOOST: 600%

⚠ The Core Challenge

Context Overflow: In large projects (1000+ lines), providing all code to the AI exceeds window limits, causing "hallucinations" or "amnesia".

✖ *Wrong: Dumping the entire codebase.*

🎯 The Golden Rule

Minimal Sufficient Context: Like a surgical operation, provide only the exact documentation, interfaces, and code snippets required for the current task.

✔ *Right: Precise, layered selection.*

📁 Layered Context Strategy

Project Constitution

Global rules, tech stack, forbidden patterns. Always Included (e.g., constitution.md).



Architecture & Modules

Module responsibilities, interfaces, data flow. On-Demand (e.g., architecture.md).



File Level

Specific source files relevant to the active task. Targeted (e.g., src/data_loader.py).



Function/Class Details

Granular snippets, specific functions to modify. Pinpoint (e.g., class DataProcessor).



Pro Tip: In tools like Cursor, combine references (e.g., @Constitution + @File) to build the perfect context.

> Reference Commands

@file Reference complete file contente.g., @data_loader.py

@folder Reference folder structure (no content)e.g., @src/analysis

@code Reference specific function/class (Precise)e.g., @calculate_kde

@docs Reference indexed documente.g., @Pandas (No context switch)

@web Browse specific URL for infoe.g., @https://stackoverflow...

@git Reference commits or diffse.g., @diff (Review changes)

🔑 High-Efficiency Prompt Construction

📁 Context Building (The "Memory")

@.ai-context/constitution.md

Level 0: Project Rules

@specs/kde/requirements.md

Level 1: Feature Specs

@code:calculate_density

Level 3: Target Function

▶ Execution Prompt (The "Action")

Based on the above specs, optimize calculate_density
: 1. Objectives: – Optimize for 100k points to < 5s – Replace loops with scipy.spatial.cKDTree
2. Constraints: – Maintain 100% Type Hints – Follow Google Style Docstring

★ Best Practices

Avoid @Folder Abuse: Large folders consume context window rapidly.

The "Combo": Always include @constitution.md for consistency.

Precision First: Use @code over @file when modifying specific functions.

⚠️ Traditional Debug: Throw error to AI → Random guesses → Fix breaks more things



🏠 Expert Prompt Template

```
@debug_report.md # Reference your symptom report
"Don't just ask AI what to do, ask it to analyze causes + design solutions."

Analyze: List 3 most likely causes for this error, ranked by probability.
Diagnose: Provide verification steps for each cause (e.g., print vars).
Fix: After confirmation, design a minimal-change fix and explain why.

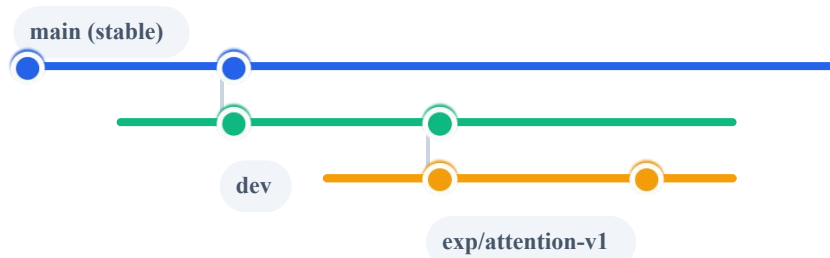
# NOTE: Do not rewrite whole files directly. Analyze first.
```

Expected Outcome
Get logic-based analysis instead of blind code patches.

💡 **Stop "Vibe Debugging"**

Git Workflow for Research

Structured branching strategy to isolate stable code from experimental features.



AI-Assisted Commit Message:

"I added attention module and fixed memory leak..."

```
feat(model): add hierarchical attention module
```

```
fix(data): resolve data loader memory leak
```

- Implement HierarchicalAttention class
- Add garbage collection after epoch

Experiment Tracking (W&B)

Move beyond Excel sheets. Use Weights & Biases for reproducible, visual tracking.



Hyperparameters

lr, batch_size, optimizer, architecture



Metrics & Performance

Train/Val Loss, Accuracy, F1 Score curves



Artifacts

Best Model (.pt), Log files, System specs

AI Prompt: "Add W&B logging to training loop"

```
import wandb

wandb.init(project="urban-flow-pred", config={
    "learning_rate": 0.001,
    "architecture": "ResNet-50"
})

# ... inside training loop ...
wandb.log({"loss": loss, "accuracy": acc})
```

PYTHON

1

Step-by-Step Description

✓

Break complex tasks into logical chains. Avoid overwhelming the AI with too much at once.

BAD VS GOOD

"Data Analysis"

"Step 1: Read CSV; Step 2: Stats; Step 3: Plot"

2

Provide Examples (Few-shot)

✓

Provide specific input/output samples for the AI to mimic exact formats.

PROMPT

EXAMPLE

Input: {'name': 'BJ', 'pop': 2154}

Output: 'Beijing Population: 21.54M'

3

Role Setting

✓

Assign expert personas to activate domain-specific knowledge weights.

PROMPT

EXAMPLE

"You are a GIS expert, proficient in GeoPandas spatial indexing..."

4

Explicit Constraints

✓

Set boundaries to prevent hallucinations or unwanted libraries.

PROMPT

EXAMPLE

"Use matplotlib only, no seaborn; processing time < 10s"

5

Iterative Optimization

✓

Do not aim for perfection in one shot. Refine in rounds.

WORKFLOW

R1: Basic Function → R2: Error Handling → R3: Perf → R4: Docs

6

AI Self-Review

✓

Use AI's reflection capability to spot bugs before running code.

PROMPT

EXAMPLE

"Please review the code above for potential memory leaks & edge cases."



Three Core Cognitions

Paradigm Shift: From "Writing Code" to "Describing Needs"

Mode Choice: Vibe Coding for speed, Spec-Driven for reliability

Tool Mindset: No "best tool," only best combinations



Three Practical Methods

Prompt Engineering: 5W1H framework & role constraints

Dev Levels: Spec-First / Anchored / As-Source three tiers

Context: Layered management & precise refs (@docs, @code)



Three Tool Strategies

Zero Budget: Antigravity + Trae (Free & Powerful)

Standard: Cursor Pro (\$20/mo) + Gemini CLI

Enterprise: Kiro (Spec-Driven) + Cursor Team

66

"AI is the copilot; you are the pilot. Master specs & tools for 10x productivity."

Always remember: Validate, Test, and Think Critically.